

Contents

1	Introduction	5
2	Theory: The regime-strength model of electoral manipulation in non-democracies	19
3	Survival of the fraudulent: Cross-national patterns of manipulation and protest outcome	51
4	Agent risk and variation in manipulation tactics in Russia	75
5	Election fraud and agent risk in Ukraine	99
6	Crime and punishment: Courts and election manipulation in Russia	125
7	Conclusions	147
8	References	149

This is a draft version.

Chapter 1

Introduction

Two small, personal stories illustrate the central aims of this book, especially when contrasted with the well-known stories of the Color Revolutions. The first of these small stories concerns Marina Tarakanova, who served as deputy chair of a precinct election commission in the seaside city of Gelendzhik (Krasnodar Krai) in 2022. Tarakanova was helping to oversee the voting for the regional legislature in her precinct, Tarakanova was confronted (and filmed) by Ilona Grachevskaya, a candidate for office from the Communist Party of the Russian Federation. The video shows Grachevskaya accusing Tarakanova of hiding pre-filled ballots. Seated comfortably, Tarakanova refuses to move until Grachevskaya, the candidate, successfully gets the police involved.

Upon instructions from an officer, Tarakanova stands, revealing the stack of ballots upon which she has been sitting; the officer rifles through the stack, showing that each has been pre-marked in favor of United Russia (“Administration of Gelendzhik: Get your butt off of our elections!” 2023). The video drew widespread publicity, to the extent that the Central Election Commission felt compelled address the issue in a televised session. The Chair of the Commission, Ella Pamfilova, scolded officials, noting that the ambitions of any party, candidate, or official are not worth the risk to the individual contemplating fraud. “It is not worth it, for this pretty young woman Tarakanova to risk her own personal reputation, along with the reputations of the election commission and the whole electoral system,” Pamfilova said. Speaking to regional election officials, Pamfilova said “I want you to carefully examine why she did this. What motivated her? (Anton Voloschenko 2022)”

In the case of Marina Tarakanova, the chair of the CEC need not have troubled herself overmuch to find a plausible explanation. According to public records, Tarakanova’s occupation was ‘main specialist’ in the department of mobilization work (i.e. the department which manages public resources for civil defense; Krasnodar Krai is a border region). For this work, her declared income in 2021

was 2,900,000 rubles: a very handsome sum for a civil servant in a region where the average yearly income was only 590,000 rubles. Her husband declared an additional income of 646,000 rubles (Maria Gridina 2022). Despite their large joint income, the couple declared renting only a small flat along with ownership of two modest vehicles (Maria Gridina 2022), though it is not unheard of for officials to omit luxury assets from such declarations (Szakonyi 2025). As a municipal employee, Tarakanova’s lucrative position—and possible future opportunities for enrichment that may exist in the civil defense sector—may have hinged on delivering satisfactory electoral results for United Russia, which dominates the regional legislature.

Whether she was indeed motivated by such patronage concerns will not be known, since—despite appeals to law enforcement by election observers, the KPRF, and even (tepidly) the ruling party (Anton Voloschenko 2022)—there has been no public investigation of the case. The chair of the regional election commission asserted that law enforcement was investigating the incident just days later (Anton Voloschenko 2022), however, no charges appear to have ever been brought against Tarakanova. Even before the incident, election monitors have for years complained to the courts in Krasnodar Krai that the regional Investigative Committee (i.e. the state prosecutor) has been quashing complaints of electoral crimes in the region (“Court in Gelendzhik Tires of the Inactivity of the Investigative Committee” 2021).

Other individuals, operating in different regions and perhaps lacking important connections, have not fared so well in the Russian legal system. In 2012, former precinct election chair Tatiana Arkhipova was convicted in court of stuffing 150 ballots in favor of United Russia’s mayoral candidate into the ballot box, while destroying 150 opposition ballots. For this, and the subsequent forgery of the election protocol, she was fined 100,000 rubles. It is perhaps important to note that Arkhipova’s case coincided with considerable turnover in the mayor’s office; before her conviction, the candidate on whose behalf Arkhipova had tampered with the election was himself convicted of bribery, removed from office, and issued a fine of 18 million rubles. Three new mayors had since served in rapid succession (“Head of Moscow-area election commission fined for falsification of votes” 2012). To foreshadow the argument to come, such disruption in the local patronage structure may have altered United Russia’s willingness or ability to protect some local agents from legal consequences. In 2023, two teachers from Orenburg were convicted of falsifying votes and fined over 260,000 rubles—about six months’ average annual wage for the region. Each year in Russia, a small number of election commissioners are convicted of falsification (Torochashnikova 2021), while many more are convicted of lesser administrative violations of electoral procedure. While real jail time is almost unheard of (Torochashnikova 2021), those who are convicted regularly receive substantial fines and/or suspended prison sentences.¹

¹This is a status similar to probation; the convicted person must regularly check in with a probationary officer and avoid committing any other infractions during the period of a

Even when convicted individuals face light sentences, there are considerable downsides to becoming a convicted criminal in Russia. For instance, Article 351.1 of Russia’s Labor Code prohibits those who “have or *have had* a criminal record, *are subject to or have been subject to* criminal prosecution” (emphasis added) for a variety of crimes from working in the field of education broadly; the listed crimes include crimes ‘against freedom of the individual’, a heading in the Russian criminal code which includes electoral manipulation. Since many of those who are pressured into manipulating elections are precinct election commissioners are teachers (Forrat 2018), exposure to the legal system also exposes these individuals to the possible loss of their career. Indeed, the law requires educational institutions to suspend teachers from work for the duration of legal proceedings (“Criminals Allowed to Work with Children” 2015), depriving individuals of income for weeks or months. All this is further complicated by the legal requirement that workers in Russia maintain a formal record of their employment (the *trudovaya knizhka*, or labor book), which they must present to prospective employers. Records of disciplinary actions may be included in this book, which can complicate an individual’s future job prospects.

These examples are, of course, peculiarities of the Russian legal system. But they serve to highlight the intertwined complexities that can arise out of a criminal prosecution or conviction (Pager 2003; Kirk and Wakefield 2018); these consequences can be expected to arise in authoritarian regimes, where courts often perform their ordinary functions outside of political cases (Shen-Bayh 2022; Ginsburg and Moustafa 2008) while serving to uphold regime legitimacy through law and order (Whiting 2017; Cheesman 2015). Front-line election actors, who are typically placed fairly low in their patronage network, expose themselves to these kinds of risks and consequences when they participate in ballot stuffing, election fraud, and other forms of illegal electoral manipulation. Such exposure is not purely theoretical, as the examples from Russia—a relatively closed electoral authoritarian regime—demonstrate.

Stories like those of the two teachers who were fined a quarter of a million rubles each largely go unremarked upon, outside of the local press and the websites of determined election monitors. Among scholars of electoral manipulation and authoritarian stability, they have likewise received little attention. Instead, researchers have often—understandably—focused on mass protest as a downstream consequence of rigged elections. Such events are hard to ignore; they often involve great physical courage and resilience on the part of the protesters, provide compelling images for national and international media, and occasionally result in the downfall of authoritarian governments. Events like the 1986 People Power Revolution in the Philippines, Ukraine’s 2004 Orange Revolution, or the 2005 Tulip Revolution in Kyrgyzstan, took a central place in theories of electoral manipulation. In these events, sometimes collectively called ‘color revolutions,’ post-election accusations of fraud contribute to mass protest, which in turn led to the fall of incumbent governments.

suspended sentence.

The dramatic and consequential events highlighted for many observers the considerable risk that incumbents entertain when they manipulate elections. The cost of such manipulation is paid in lost popular legitimacy (Birch 2011); when an election appears sufficiently fraudulent, costly and potentially destabilizing citizen resistance can occur. Or, as others framed it, the use of election manipulation *reveals* the regime’s existing lack of popular legitimacy, making opposition parties more confident in their chances of successfully ousting the incumbent through protest (Fearon 2011; Andrew T. Little 2012a; Andrew T. Little, Tucker, and LaGatta 2015a; Magaloni 2010). Qualitative studies further developed the importance of opposition parties and civil society organizations in detecting and publicizing evidence of manipulation, in order to improve the likelihood of protest success (Valerie Bunce and Wolchik 2006). This overall approach, in which electoral manipulation imposes a cost on manipulators in the form of costly risk to their tenure in office, has become a commonplace assumption in the literature on election manipulation.

In this book, I offer significant challenges to this this assumption, which I describe as the *regime-weakness model of electoral manipulation*. Instead, building on work by Simpser (Simpser 2013), Rundlett and Svulik (Rundlett and Svulik 2016), and myself (Harvey 2019, 2022a, 2016), I develop a *regime-strength* model of electoral manipulation in non-democracies. The regime-strength model address several questions that are puzzling under the regime-weakness framework: why does election manipulation persist in places where protest risk is high (as evidenced by the Color Revolutions themselves)? Why do incumbents often claim unbelievably high electoral results (like Belarusian president Aleksandr Lukashenko’s ostensible 81 percent vote-share—with 84 percent turnout!—in 2020), if election manipulation is cheap talk that is likely to prompt costly protest? More significantly, it points toward more effective, though more difficult, measures of improving electoral integrity than reliance on the general public to act as a sort of natural immune system against rigged elections (Fearon 2011). To effectively improve electoral integrity, reformers and opposition actors must interrupt the machinery of manipulation by breaking the links between political principals and election-rigging agents.

The regime-strength model of electoral manipulation offers a pessimistic prognosis: the authoritarian incumbents who are best at rigging elections are also likely to be the best at surviving protest movements. The capacities and resources that authoritarian leaders need to engage the machinery of manipulation are the same as those needed to control society more broadly: extensive patronage networks, legal impunity for pro-regime agents. Incumbents in electoral authoritarian regimes are incentivized to build these capacities; moreover, the more incumbents face a credible opposition threat, the *more* incentivized they are to build such capacities. As a result, the regime-strength model makes predictions that are diametrically opposed to those of the standard model; namely, electoral manipulation is likely to be more severe when protest risk is higher, and (if protests do occur), more manipulation is likely to be associated with quicker defeat for protest movements.

Multiparty elections are a fundamental component of post-Cold War authoritarian politics (Magaloni and Kricheli 2010; Jennifer Gandhi and Lust-Okar 2009; Donno 2013). Elections have been found to have multiple benefits for authoritarian regime survival, including through the co-optation of certain electoral blocs (J. Gandhi and Przeworski 2007; Jennifer Gandhi and Przeworski 2006; Ora John Reuter and Robertson 2015), the recruitment of effective politicians and agents (Greene 2007; Lust-Okar 2006), the revelation of information about political actors (Simpser 2013; Miller 2013), and the promotion of domestic and international legitimacy (Isiksel and Pepinsky 2025; S. Levitsky and Way 2010). Election manipulation is at the core of this process in authoritarian regimes. Authoritarian leaders use of a suite of tools (Schedler 2002a) to manage the uncertainty inherent in elections, which, after all, provide a focal point for opposition activity (Knutsen, Nygård, and Wig 2017). To reduce the risk of electoral loss at the outset, authoritarian incumbents often deploy pre-election restrictions (Szakonyi 2021; Bækken 2015; M. Popova 2012), repression (Bhasin and Gandhi 2013), favorable institutional frameworks (Golosov 2017; Birch 2007; Ong 2018; Tan 2013).

However, these tools alone are often insufficient to achieve incumbents' aims. Electoral institutions that were fit for purpose years ago may no longer serve the regime's needs. An unexpectedly popular challenger may emerge. Economic conditions can deteriorate, damaging the incumbent's popularity. Even when pre-election rigging is working as expected, incumbents still need a mechanism to drive high turnout in uncompetitive elections. Finally, incumbents can use their control over resources and ability to break the rules to send signals of dominance that make other actors in society more apt to cooperate (Simpser 2013; Gehlbach and Simpser 2015). To accomplish these goals, incumbents frequently turn to illegal forms of manipulation occur on or just before election day: vote-buying, voter pressure, ballot-stuffing, and outright falsification of results.

Consequently, the findings of this book improve our understanding of more than electoral manipulation alone (though this is already an important subject, due to the normative importance of electoral integrity). By identifying when electoral manipulation efforts are likely to succeed or fail, and what kinds of regimes are most likely to succeed, this book sheds light on major theoretical issues in comparative politics. These include, most directly, the stability of authoritarian regimes and the likelihood of further autocratization. They also provide insights into the role elections play in democratization, and the have some implications for democratic backsliding.

1.1 Existing explanations of electoral manipulation, and their limitations

Election manipulation has long been understood to carry costs to incumbents that are fundamentally rooted in the loss of legitimacy. In an early influential study of historical electoral manipulation in Costa Rica, Lehoucq and Molina argue that the shift to more coercive and illegitimate forms of electoral manipulation, in combination with increasing targeting of more literate and densely populated communities “scandalized major sectors of the public,” contributing to anti-government insurrections in the 1940s (F. Lehoucq and Molina 2002). The concept of the ‘legitimacy cost’ of manipulation (in contrast to its organizational resource cost) was developed at length by Birch (2011), who argues that “feared loss of legitimacy—domestic and international—is the most significant deterrent to electoral manipulation” (p. 56). Drawing on World Values Survey data, Norris (Norris 2014) finds some empirical evidence of legitimacy costs along several dimensions.

As the literature developed, events like the color revolutions figured prominently in theories of election manipulation and how it might be restrained. The role of legitimacy loss—and protest risk in particular—in preventing electoral manipulation has become especially influential in the formal modeling tradition. In some models, use of electoral manipulation is itself a signal of low incumbent legitimacy. According to this logic, some incumbents rely on manipulation to secure electoral victory, but—concerned about the potential costs of mass protests—some may instead opt to hold relatively fair elections. This approach carries a normatively hopeful message: strong opposition movements—those that are well-organized, well-funded, and enjoy broad public support—can effectively discourage incumbents from manipulating elections. As a result, the chances of democratic transition and consolidation increase. I refer to this as the “regime-weakness model” of manipulation.

There are, generally speaking, two versions of the regime-weakness model. These are illustrated in Figure 1.1. In both versions, weaker incumbents are defined by their low popularity and low likelihood of winning a clean election. This gives them an incentive to produce more electoral manipulation, to overcome their electoral weakness. However, doing so also creates risks. In the first, depicted in Panel A, awareness of electoral manipulation induces a loss of legitimacy among the public (Birch 2011); in other words, people are upset at violations of procedural justice (Cho and Kim 2016), and especially incensed if they believe the election was ‘stolen’ (Kuntz and Thompson 2009; Tucker 2007). The focal point of the election allows individuals with diverse grievances to overcome their collective action problems and mobilize against the incumbent (Tucker 2007). There is a direct risk that a politically stronger opposition—one that is unified, well-resourced, etc.—can initiate protests on its own. But the decision to engage in manipulation, and thus provide aggrieved citizens with a further, unifying grievance, intensifies that risk. As such, the more costly the expected

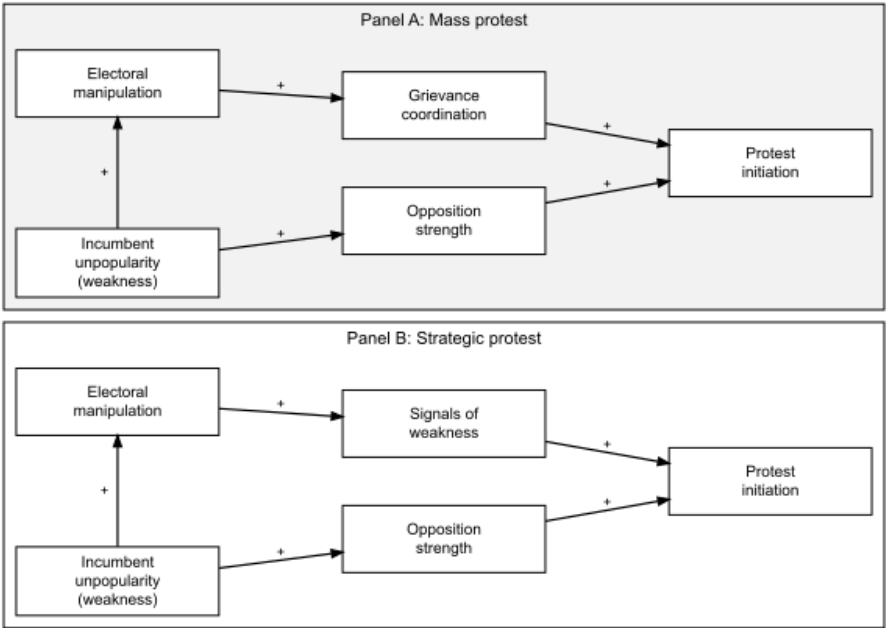


Figure 1.1: Regime-weakness models of electoral manipulation and opposition protest

protest, the more an incumbent is disincentivized to rely on extensive electoral manipulation.

In the second approach, incumbent weakness is formally built into models of electoral manipulation. In this approach, electoral protest is modeled as a strategic decision by a rational opposition actor. The incumbent's likelihood of fending off a protest movement is typically treated as equivalent to its popularity. Election fraud is a tool that allows unpopular incumbents to win elections; thus, when the opposition detects fraud it revises its belief about the incumbent's popularity downward. Election fraud can get the incumbent across the finish line in the election, but at the risk of signaling weakness to the opposition and prompting a costly protest response. This type of model predicts that opposition parties that are more capable of mobilizing protest, as well as institutional and contextual features that expose manipulation efforts, help deter election manipulation (Andrew T. Little 2012a; Chernykh and Svolik 2015; Luo and Rozenas 2020). Figure 1.1 illustrates this logic in Panel B. As the figure shows, both versions of the regime-weakness model imply that weaker incumbents face some baseline risk of protest due to their weakness / unpopularity, but that incumbents increase the risk of mass protest the more they rely on electoral manipulation (Luo and Rozenas 2017; Andrew T. Little 2012a; Schedler 2002b; Emily Beaulieu 2014; Andrew T. Little, Tucker, and LaGatta 2015b). By the same token, they can reduce the risk of protest by holding cleaner elections.²

The regime-weakness model, while very plausible, produces some conceptual puzzles. Why, for instance, do incumbents claim excessive margins of victory (indicating massive falsification), if falsification is a signal of weakness? Under the regime-weakness model, the occurrence of post-election protest is *the* sign that informal negotiations between the incumbent and the opposition have broken down (Emily Beaulieu 2014); the incumbent has manipulated 'too much' given the opposition's strength. Given that the incumbent can choose how much election fraud to implement, why do we observe protest—what prevents incumbents from 'correctly' targeting the level of election fraud? And, perhaps most puzzling, why is it that most electoral protests fail to oust incumbents?

Scholars have, of course, advanced answers to these questions. Incumbents may claim unbelievably large margins of victory because that is what the opposition expects; perhaps it is the deviation from this expectation that triggers protest (Andrew T. Little 2012a). Manipulated elections that trigger protest may occur due to incomplete information, as both sides overestimate their chances of success in a post-election conflict (Smyth 2020). Likewise, over-optimistic opposition actors may produce the surfeit of unsuccessful protests that we observe.

Alternative answers to these questions are proposed in Simpson's model of elec-

²Readers who are familiar with the directed acyclic graph notation for causal relationships will also note that incumbent unpopularity / weakness is positioned as a confounder of the relationship between election manipulation and protest initiation. Since it is difficult for even incumbents in authoritarian regimes to gauge their true popularity (much less outside analysts), it is difficult to close this 'backdoor path' and assess the validity of this model.

toral manipulation as a costly signal of incumbents' resources and capacities, which in turn influence other actors' expectations of the likelihood the incumbent will remain in office. Incumbents who blatantly or excessively manipulate elections demonstrate they have deep financial and organizational resources, and a willingness to break the law. In turn, elites, political parties, bureaucrats, and ordinary citizens expect the incumbent to remain in office in the future; these expectations lead to cooperative behavior with the incumbent, helping entrench their rule (Simpser 2013). According to this view, manipulation does not (merely) reveal a lack of popularity, but may also highlight other forms of resilience that can offset low public approval. A simplified illustration of Simpser's approach is presented in Figure 1.2.

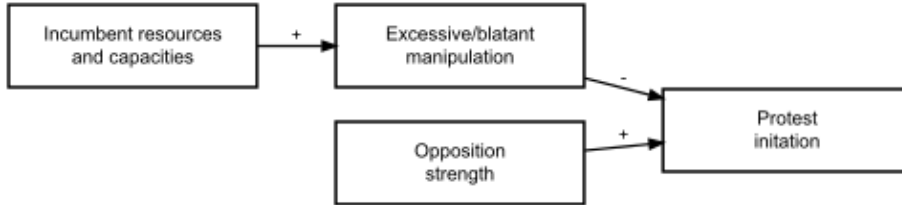


Figure 1.2: Simpser's model of electoral manipulation and opposition protest

As Figures 1.1 and 1.2 show, it should in principle be straightforward to distinguish between these two models empirically. In the regime-weakness model, electoral manipulation increases the risk of post-election protest; in the Simpser model, manipulation reduces the likelihood of protest (so long as it is excessive and/or blatant). However, empirical studies have not been able to conclusively settle this debate. Some studies have found that increased manipulation is associated with greater likelihood of protest, as the regime-weakness model would predict, while others have found no effect (S. Hyde and Marinov 2014; U. E. Daxecker 2012; Hafner-Burton, Hyde, and Jablonski 2016; Lankina and Skovoroda 2017; Ananyev and Poyker 2022). A straightforward selection between the competing models of electoral manipulation has eluded the field, as a result.

1.2 Theory in brief

In this book, I propose an alternative conceptualization of how electoral manipulation relates to authoritarian regime resilience and protest, by integrating Simpser's argument with more recent work uncovering the principal-agent relationships inherent in electoral manipulation efforts. I call this the regime-strength model of electoral manipulation, and argue that it best explains the use and consequences of electoral manipulation techniques. Figure 1.3 illustrates the regime-strength model.

Incumbents in authoritarian regimes face the risk of revolutionary uprising as well as the risk of insider defection (Milan W. Svolik 2012). These risks can be

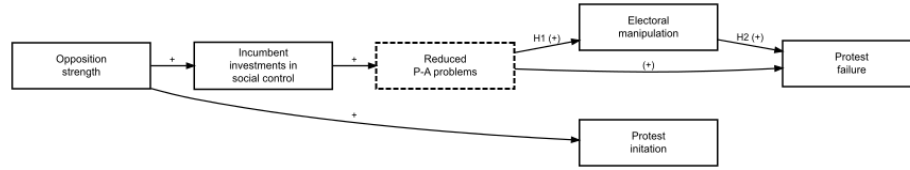


Figure 1.3: A regime-strength model of electoral manipulation and opposition protest

intertwined (Sato and Wahman 2019), as mass protest can spark elite defections (Río 2022), and elites who split from the ruling coalition can use their own resources to stoke mass protest (Robertson 2010). When faced with relatively greater dangers to their position, whether it be mass- or elite-driven, incumbents in authoritarian regimes invest in various means of social control. To reduce the risk of being ousted, leaders will adjust institutions, attempt to purge elites or reduce their influence, shower benefits on cronies, and engage in repressive measures (Bueno de Mesquita et al. 2005). They build parties of power that channel patronage resources and elite ambitions (O. Reuter and Remington 2009; Ora John Reuter 2010; Magaloni 2008; Greene 2007), and co-opt their rivals using access to rents (Ora John Reuter and Robertson 2015; Jennifer Gandhi 2008; Blaydes 2011). They censor traditional and social media in order to control the flow of information (King, Pan, and Roberts 2013; Geddes and Zaller 1989; Lankina, Watanabe, and Netesova 2020). They fine-tune the independence of courts in order to optimize both political control and perceived legitimacy (Ginsburg and Moustafa 2008). And they build, deploy, and take pains to coup-proof the security forces to manage threats (Davenport 1995; Bhasin and Gandhi 2013; Makara 2013). The greater the threats faced by incumbents, the more they are motivated to develop these tools of control in order to retain their position (Milan W. Svolik 2012), all the more so, since loss of incumbency in an authoritarian regime often comes with steep personal penalties (e.g. loss of assets, imprisonment, exile, or death).

In their efforts to govern and remain in power, authoritarian leaders must also contend with substantial principal-agent problems. Not even the most powerful dictator can rule alone; they require the cooperation of a vast network of actors, from their immediate subordinates down through a range of bureaucrats and mid-level elites, all the way down to ordinary citizens. At every stage, a subordinate's goals may diverge from those of the leader. The leader's closest allies are often the very ones who oust him; the very repressive forces which the dictator relies on to defend the regime from mass uprising may use their resources to topple him (Chin, Song, and Wright 2023; Milan W. Svolik 2012). To keep the repressive apparatus loyal, the dictator must offer them spoils—but not too much, lest they use their resources to overthrow the boss (Dragu and Przeworski 2019). Likewise, the incumbent may tolerate some level of corruption among his subordinates, but excessive corruption threatens mass unrest and also deprives

the leader himself of some sources of rents; on the other hand, individuals have strong incentives to extract as much as they can from their positions of power. The incumbent may wish for judges to rule in his favor, but those judges may be eyeing the possibility that the opposition will take power, and hedge their bets (Hilbink 2007; Helmke 2012; M. Popova 2012). Finally, the individuals charged with manipulating an election on the leader's behalf may have their own incentives to shirk, either to pocket their payments or to avoid exposure (Rundlett and Svolik 2016; Harvey 2019).

Incumbents can mitigate these principal-agent problems through monitoring and punishing defection (Ginsburg 2008), though this can be difficult given the opaque information environment and agents' incentives to misrepresent their behavior (Tutumlu and Rustemov 2021; Boix and Svolik 2013). Loyalty can be assured through shared characteristics between leader and agent (Milan W. Svolik 2009), like extended family ties, or shared revolutionary experience (S. R. Levitsky and Way 2012). More generally, incumbents work to ensure that their subordinates incentives are aligned with their own; that is, that they will be genuinely loyal out of self-interest (Egorov and Sonin 2011). A fundamental key to maintaining agents' loyalty is the power of expectations (Henry E. Hale 2014). If I expect the incumbent to be in power tomorrow, with the attendant ability to reward and punish, I am more incentivized to work on his behalf today. This, of course, becomes a self-fulfilling prophecy: the more agents are incentivized to work on the incumbent's behalf today, the more likely he is to remain in office tomorrow.

In electoral authoritarian regimes, election manipulation has a uniquely central role in this dynamic. On one hand, successful election manipulation is essential for setting up the expectation that the incumbent's time in office will continue indefinitely. On the other hand, as with other aspects of authoritarian politics, the likelihood of 'successful' manipulation is itself subject to principal-agent problems (Rundlett and Svolik 2016; Harvey 2019). This means that, as incumbents respond to threats to their power by investing in the repressive apparatus, installing loyalists in key positions, centralizing control over patronage resources, and so on, they also reduce agency loss among election-manipulating agents. When those agents' incentives are more closely aligned with the leader's, because of the leader's increasingly well-developed tools of social control, it is more likely that they will carry out their duties. In particular, as developed in more detail in the next chapter, I argue that centralize control over patronage networks and minimizing personal risks to agents (e.g. through compliant police and courts, or the absence of election monitoring) reduces agency loss among election manipulating agents.

This theory produces two direct hypotheses, and one indirect implication. First, it holds that electoral manipulation should increase in severity with opposition strength and with indicators of social control (i.e. low risk to agents, high resource control by the incumbent). Second, it predicts that increased electoral manipulation will be associated with a greater risk of *protest failure*—that is,

with the likelihood that incumbents will defeat protest movements. Part of this effect, I argue, is directly attributable to manipulation itself. The more intensively an incumbent is able to manipulate the election, the more he signals that he has overcome a variety of principal-agent problems. This complements Simpson's view that excessive manipulation transmits information about the regime's capabilities. The more severely the election is manipulated, the more confident other regime actors will feel in the likelihood that the regime will survive the protest threat. In turn, they are more motivated to support the incumbent and deprive the opposition of support. Part of the effect, however, is not a causal effect of manipulation—incumbents who are good at manipulating elections are also good at social control generally, making them more likely to defeat challengers.

Finally, this theory also offers an explanation for the mixed relationship between manipulation and protest that has been observed in the data. In this model, contrary to both the regime-weakness and Simpson approaches, there is no direct linkage between the degree of electoral manipulation and protest initiation. Instead, the occurrence of electoral protest is driven by the existence of the election and opposition strength, not by the degree to which the election has been rigged. Elections, at any level of integrity, create opportunities for contestation. The stronger an opposition group is—i.e. the more popular, unified, and well-resourced it is—the more likely it is to stage post-election protest. Whether electoral manipulation is associated with high or low levels of manipulation is contingent on the degree to which the incumbent has developed tools of social control. Where such tools are well developed in response to opposition strength, we should expect to see severe manipulation and a high likelihood of protest. However, when the incumbent has been less successful in developing tools of control, we are likely to observe protest in the context of a weakly manipulated election. The relationship that scholars find in their work, thus, hinges on case selection.

1.3 Plan of the book

Chapter 2 develops the regime-strength model of manipulation in more detail; subsequent chapters explore empirical implications of the model. Chapter 3 tests the three main hypotheses of the book on a cross-national dataset of electoral authoritarian regimes from 1989 to 2012. Combining data from NELDA (Susan D. Hyde and Marinov 2012), V-Dem version 15 (Coppedge, Gerring, Knutsen, Lindberg, Teorell, Altman, Angiolillo, Bernhard, Cornell, Fish, Fox, Gastaldi, Gjerløw, Glynn, Good God, Grahn, Hicken, Kinzelbach, Krusell, et al. 2025), and the Electoral Contention and Violence dataset (U. Daxecker, Amicarelli, and Jung 2019), the quantitative analysis shows that 1) electoral protest is more likely to occur when elections are highly manipulated but oppositions are strong, but not when elections are highly manipulated and oppositions are weak, 2) that protest movements are defeated more quickly in cases where the incumbent

manipulated more extensively, and 3) that incumbents facing a greater risk of protest tend to manipulate *more* than those facing a low risk of protest.

Chapters 4 and 5 use the Russian case to test the mechanisms described in the theory. Chapter 4 uses precinct-level election data from ten national elections from 2001 to 2021. Each Russian election produces data from roughly 100,000 precincts, amounting to a total of approximately one million data points. These results are nested within Russia’s regions. This allows for a comparative analysis of election outcomes across regions, while holding the national-level political context constant each election year. I use election forensic techniques to estimate the degree of election fraud and vote-buying / ballot-stuffing in each region-year. Taking these estimates as dependent variables shows that increasing local risk of exposure leads to reduced election falsification, but *increased* ballot-stuffing and vote-buying. This result supports the principal-agent mechanism of the regime-strength model, showing that incumbents still desire rigged elections when risk of exposure is high, but agents are less willing to put themselves at risk.

Chapter 5 uses original data from the Russian court system to show how electoral crimes are handled in a highly authoritarian context, and how legal penalties for agents in one election reverberate to the next. To construct this original dataset, I scraped the Russian legal database sudact.ru for election-related court outcomes. Of the several thousand such cases, I hand-coded the outcome for perpetrators in the few hundred cases that relate to election falsification. I then match these outcomes to subsequent election results in the region; the statistical analysis shows that when agents face stiff penalties (i.e. large fines or jail time), subsequent election fraud in the region declines significantly. Light penalties, on the other hand, are associated with subsequent increases in fraud.

This debate has significant theoretical stakes for major questions of democratization and autocratization. The regime-weakness model of manipulation is optimistic; incumbents who wish to avoid revealing their weakness to strategic protesters may reduce or even eschew manipulation—an auspicious prediction that under-pins the idea of ‘self-enforcing’ democracy (Fearon 2011). However, if manipulation can indicate regime resilience, incumbents have incentives to both develop and deploy the machinery of manipulation—a gloomy prediction for democratization and democratic resilience.